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BENNETT BLAMED

150 jobs waiting, mine boss claims

Premier W. A. C. Bennett asked the citizens of B.C. Wednesday what jobs they could provide for the province.

Thursday, Sydney Fowlds, president of the Vancouver mining company Crownex International Ltd., had an answer.

He said he could provide up to 150 jobs immediately, and maybe 200 indirect jobs eventually, at the Sunro copper mine at Jordan River, about 40 miles west of Victoria.

But there's a catch.

After reading the report of Bennett's question, Fowlds phoned The Sun to say the jobs are ready and waiting — waiting for approval from the pollution control board.

And the reason the approval has not yet been granted, Fowlds claimed, is a lack of communication between Bennett's own government departments.

"My answer to Mr. Bennett's question is that we're offering jobs and he is not accepting them," Fowlds said.

"If Mr. Bennett is going to ask a question like that, he has to make sure his departments are co-ordinated to provide the help in setting up the businesses which provide the jobs."

The 1,500-ton-a-day Sunro mine, closed down in 1968, was taken over in 1969 by Dison Development Ltd., which is now owned equally by Crownex and Pechiney Development Ltd., of Paris.

Fowlds said Pechiney, as its part of the purchase, has invested $500,000 in re-opening the mine.

And the two companies, once they get the pollution board go-ahead, will invest another $1.75 million for capital improvement and $1 million for working capital, Fowlds said.

Fowlds said the only reason the permit wasn't granted was because of objections by the health department and the department of recreation and conservation.

"We haven't been told what these objections are but we are sure we can meet them," he said.

"I'm sure they haven't bothered to investigate the technical evidence we provided. If they had I'm sure they would have had their objections answered.

"If there was proper communications between the government departments the application would have been read by the people who objected," he said.

"The reason I'm blaming Bennett is that he is responsible for those departments."

Fowlds said Dison Developments would consider modifying its proposal if necessary to meet obligations.

The application, to dump up to one million gallons of effluent — copper mine tailings — into the Strait of Juan de Fuca near the Jordan River on the west coast of Vancouver Island, was turned down June 1.

A spokesman for the pollution control board said the company has appealed the board's rejection.

The appeal will be heard June 29 at 10 a.m. in the provincial museum building in Victoria.

The spokesman said the company could go further after this month's hearing by appealing to the cabinet or the Supreme Court.

Fowlds said the pollution board refused automatically because the other government departments had the unspecified objections.

He said the company hired University of B.C. oceanographers who decided the eight years of dumping tailings directly into the water had done no damage to fish or plant life in the area.

The oceanographers found that strong tidal action in the area carried the effluent — containing copper, chromium, cadmium and cyanide — two miles out to sea before it sinks to the ocean floor.

This evidence was corroborated by federal fisheries department findings, Fowlds said.

And, given this evidence, objections voiced by the Pacific Trollers' Association and the Scientific Pollution and Environmental Control Society are "based on emotion not fact," he said.

Jordan River residents had complained about mine tailings polluting the beach when they were dumped in the ocean near the shore by the Sunro mine's earlier owner, the now defunct Cowichan Copper Ltd.

But Fowlds said — and the pollution board was told — Dison Developments proposed dumping in an area where there was a stronger current and pumping the effluent out under the low water mark instead of on the surface.

"The residents couldn't have read our proposals. If they had they would have realized it would be different from the past," he said.

"That's a depressed area— it needs the jobs our mine can provide."

FORMER CHURCH HEAD

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